

Islamic Republic of Pakistan

The Question of Child Marriage,

IRL Stance: Balance w each province having their own laws surrounding it depending on what tribe/village.

Background of Problem	Past Actions		Solutions	Motions
	International	National		
Every year, millions of children, particularly girls, are impacted by the pervasive worldwide problem of child marriage. More than 650 million women in the world today were married before turning 18, according to UNICEF. An estimated 12 million girls get married before they reach adulthood every year. This practice is most common in parts of South Asia, sub-Saharan Africa, and some parts of the Middle East and Latin America, though it is found throughout the world. Niger, the Central African Republic, Chad, Bangladesh, and Mali have the highest rates, with over half of girls getting married before they turn 18.	1. The 1989 Convention on the Rights of the Child. It calls for protection from harmful practices and defines a child as anyone under the age of 18. The United States is still the only UN member that has not ratified the CRC, and many signatories—particularly in regions of the Middle East and South Asia, interpret "child" differently	1. The 2013 Sindh Child Marriage Restriction Act The Sindh Child Marriage Restriction Act of 2013 is the most significant measure Pakistan has taken to prevent child marriage. The country's first provincial law to raise the legal marriage age for both boys and girls to 18 was this one. Anyone who plans, performs, or assists in a child marriage faces explicit criminal penalties of up to three years in prison and fines, including witnesses and	Pakistan suggests an international model that can be used to improve coordination among local institutions and guarantee efficient regulation of underage marriage, particularly in nations where formal law and customary practices coexist. According to this model, a centralized digital registration system will be established and made available locally by village councils, government agencies, and religious leaders. It would be necessary for community leaders,	Motion to “Regulated Marriage Systems instead of a Blanket Ban”. Motion to explore how education and stable jobs can reduce the pressure for early marriage. Motion to discuss regional

Although the reasons behind child marriage differ from nation to nation and area to region, poverty, illiteracy, gender inequality, social norms, and cultural or religious traditions are frequently linked to the practice. Many communities view the practice of marrying off a daughter at a young age as a means of easing financial strain or shielding her from alleged dangers like sexual assault, social disgrace, or the inability to marry later because of poverty. Marriage becomes the norm in areas where girls' education is scarce or undervalued. Child marriage almost always leads to long-term harm, even though some families frame it as a protective measure. Early marriage increases a girl's risk of dropping out of school, getting pregnant early and often, experiencing pregnancy-related problems, and being the victim of domestic abuse. Additionally, they are more likely to be poor and have little control over their own lives. These consequences have broader ramifications for social stability, economic growth, and public health in addition to being disastrous for individual girls.	according to traditional or religious definitions. 2.8. Girls Not Brides (2011). Civil society partnership collaborates with grassroots organizations in more than 100 countries. Nevertheless, it depends on NGO cooperation and lacks enforcement power. Direct action is practically impossible in some authoritarian or war-torn nations, like Somalia or North Korea. 3.3. The 1979 CEDAW. States are required by CEDAW to outlaw discriminatory practices against women, such as child marriage. However, a lot of nations have expressed skepticism about	religious leaders. Because it was more in line with international norms, this act established a precedent for Pakistani law. The law gives courts, police, and civil society the legal authority to step in and stop early marriages, despite enforcement challenges, particularly in remote areas. 2. The 2015 Punjab Marriage Restriction (Amendment) Act The most populous province in Pakistan, Punjab, implemented the second-most significant measure. The amendment greatly increased the penalties for anyone who arranges a marriage below the legal age, even though the legal minimum age for girls is still 16. Penalties for violators include fines of up to 50,000 Pakistani rupees and imprisonment for up to six months. The law also strengthened	clerics, and marriage registrars to submit basic information, such as proof of age, with real-time comparisons to national ID databases (like Pakistan's NADRA or other comparable civil registries). Clerics, medical professionals, and local authorities would all receive regular training on child protection, reporting procedures, and legal requirements. A multi-agency coordination taskforce comprising representatives from education, health, law, and religious affairs would be formed at the district and national levels to improve accountability. Its duties would include reviewing cases, monitoring compliance, and suggesting community-specific interventions. This strategy preserves national oversight while	cooperation on early marriage reform in South Asia, Africa, and the Middle East. Motion to discuss the effectiveness of culturally adapted legal frameworks in regulating child marriage.
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Child marriage is acknowledged as a violation of human rights by numerous governments and organizations worldwide. The practice must end, according to international agreements like the Convention on the Rights of the Child and the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women. Laws to raise the legal marriage age to 18 have been proposed in a number of nations. But legal changes by themselves have frequently not been enough, especially in places with lax enforcement and strong cultural opposition. Child marriage is still a major issue in Pakistan. About 18 percent of girls get married before turning 18, and many of these marriages take place in rural areas where traditional customs predominate and poverty is extreme. While Pakistan has made some strides, such as enacting legislation in Sindh province that sets the legal marriage age at 18, other provinces continue to allow marriages at younger ages with the approval of the court or parents. The impact of these laws is still constrained by cultural norms, religious	articles that go against religious law. For instance, CEDAW's enforcement authority is diminished in Pakistan, Iran, and Saudi Arabia since they accept it but reject its provisions that conflict with Sharia law.	enforcement of marriage registration laws, which helped lower the number of underage and illegal unions. Punjab's legal changes made it much more difficult to arrange a child marriage without consequences, even though the age was not raised to 18. They also demonstrated that advancements can still be made within religious and cultural frameworks. 3. The Program for Lady Health Workers (LHWs) One of Pakistan's most successful national initiatives to lessen the negative effects of early marriage, particularly in rural areas, is the Lady Health Worker program. The program offers young brides access to reproductive counseling, birth spacing education, and maternal healthcare through more than 125,000 trained female health workers who are deployed throughout the nation. The LHW	enabling flexible enforcement based on local circumstances. This system can assist nations worldwide in efficiently monitoring marriages without criminalizing custom or alienating communities, by combining digital verification, local accountability, and cross-sector cooperation.	
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interpretations, and ignorance. It takes more than just legal action to address the problem of child marriage. It calls for a comprehensive strategy that includes funding girls' education, expanding access to reproductive and medical care, lowering poverty, and fostering discussions about human rights and gender equality in local communities. To guarantee that every child, regardless of where they live, has the chance to grow up free from the burdens of an early marriage and be able to influence their own future, international cooperation and culturally sensitive approaches are crucial.		program greatly lowers the health risks of early pregnancies and promotes the wellbeing of girls, even though it does not specifically address child marriage. Its penetration into conservative and isolated regions has established it as a reliable and uncontroversial harm reduction strategy.		
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CLARIFICATIONS:

Digital Rollout: "We acknowledge the present constraints in rural connectivity, even though Pakistan suggests a centralized digital registration system as a long-term objective. We propose a hybrid model that uses paper-based verification at village union councils, which are already in place across the country, in the short term. Regional digitization of these records is then possible. While the government and foreign donors fund the development of infrastructure for rural districts, a rapid rollout strategy can start in urban and semi-urban areas first. Long-term, this phased strategy guarantees that no community is left behind while continuing to advance national accountability.

A multi-agency coordination taskforce: The multi-agency taskforce serves purposes beyond simple oversight. Its actual purpose is to convert data into focused action. For instance, the taskforce can promptly organize interventions — such as sending mobile

health clinics, sending community educators, or bringing in local religious leaders to have discussions — if registration data indicates that a district has a high percentage of unverified marriages. In order to stop families from using early marriage as a coping mechanism, the taskforce can initiate emergency financial relief programs if the number of early marriages increases during recessions or following natural disasters. To put it briefly, the taskforce transforms unprocessed data into localized, real-time solutions, which is what will eventually lower the number of child marriages.

Added background of Pakistan:

GSL:

The delegate of Pakistan believes that, any solution to the problem of child marriage, must be based on respect for religion, cultural awareness, and real-world application.

Pakistan has taken significant action to control early marriage in Pakistan. In Punjab, the government recently implemented reforms that greatly reduced barriers for remote communities by extending registration deadlines and making birth and death registration free. To consolidate birth, death, and marriage data across provinces, Pakistan is constructing a centralized Civil Registration and Vital Statistics (CRVS) system in collaboration with UNFPA and other international partners.

That is why Pakistan proposes a globally adaptable solution: a hybrid marriage registration system, beginning with local union councils and gradually expanding into digital platforms. This ensures inclusivity in rural areas while building toward long-term infrastructure. We also propose the formation of multi-agency taskforces that not only monitor data but actively coordinate health, education, and financial responses in regions where child marriage is most prevalent. Pakistan stands ready to collaborate on solutions that are practical, respectful, and rooted in the realities our communities live every day.

SPEECHES:

Motion to explore how education and stable jobs can reduce the pressure for early marriage.

The delegate of Pakistan believes that the causes of child marriage are frequently desperation brought on by poverty, insecurity, and a lack of opportunities rather than just tradition. The decision becomes one of survival when a family must decide whether to marry off their daughter or keep her in school with no guarantee of a stable future. How can the global community support girls' futures so that early marriage isn't their only option?

According to Pakistan's experience, early marriage is frequently a reaction to financial instability, limited access to education, and a lack of life options, especially for young girls in rural areas. It is not just a cultural or religious issue. Marriage is no longer the only option for surviving when girls are enrolled in school and families are able to imagine a stable financial future. We have observed observable declines in early unions in areas where Pakistan has expanded secondary school enrollment for women and

implemented community livelihood initiatives. There is no doubt about the correlation.

This motion calls on the international community to talk about practical, development-based solutions rather than just focusing on punishment and law enforcement. By giving young people hope, education, and job security, we can lessen the pressures that lead to early marriage.

Thank you.

BLIND SPOTS;

The United States is the only UN member state that has not ratified the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC), despite regularly portraying itself as a global champion of children's rights. Furthermore, 34 U.S. states still permit child marriage, with some allowing minors to get married with parental or court approval and no set minimum age. Between 2000 and 2018, more than 300,000 children were legally married in the United States, many to elderly people, according to Equality Now. When promoting universal child protection standards, these contradictions undermine American moral authority.

The United Kingdom only fully banned child marriage in 2023, raising the legal age of marriage from 16 to 18, even with parental consent. According to The 19th News, the previous legal loophole had long enabled forced marriages within migrant and religious communities. Additionally, the UK's colonial legacy continues to shape outdated marriage laws in many former colonies. When the UK promotes global reforms, it must also reckon with the systems it left behind and the contradictions within its own recent policies.

Indonesia raised the legal marriage age for girls to 19 in 2019, yet child marriage continues under religious exemptions. According to Reuters and the Asia Pacific News, religious courts can still approve marriages for girls under the age of 16, especially in conservative regions. UNICEF reports that approximately 3,500 girls are married every day in Indonesia. This gap between legislation and religious practice reflects deep structural issues, limiting Indonesia's credibility in pushing for consistent global reforms on child marriage.

The legal marriage age in Russia is officially set at 18, but regional exceptions frequently allow girls to get married as early as 16—and in some cases, as young as 14—usually due to medical necessity or pregnancy (e.g., in Bashkortostan or Chechnya). The Borgen Project. Approximately 5.4 million women in Russia's 20–24 age group, or 6% of the country's total population, were married or in a union before turning 18. This information comes from UNICEF. Even though this rate is low when compared to global averages, child marriage is still a problem, particularly in ethnic minority communities and the North Caucasus, where cultural norms continue to justify early marriages in the face of lax local enforcement and limited civil society space (Girls Not Brides Borgen

Project). This disparity between nations, alongside limitations on NGO activity, undermines Russia's credibility in calling for universal child protection laws elsewhere.

Despite setting the marriage age at 20 for women and 22 for men, **China** does not publish any national statistics on child marriage, which makes transparency all but impossible. China is absent from international datasets, according to UNICEF, which raises concerns about underreported early marriages in ethnic or rural areas like Tibet and Xinjiang. China's lack of legal alignment with the international standard of 18 and the strict restrictions placed on civil society make it less credible in discussions about child rights around the world.

Over 3,300 child marriages occurred in England and Wales between 2008 and 2020 as a result of the **UK's legal allowance** of child marriages starting at age 16 with parental consent until 2023 (Girls Not Brides UK). Coercion was used in many, particularly in immigrant communities. Early marriage laws were also exported by the UK throughout its empire. Without addressing that legacy, promoting global reforms runs the risk of being hypocritical rather than leading.

With more than 1.5 million girls married before the age of 18, **India** has the highest number of child brides worldwide, according to UNICEF. Even though the legal age is 18, enforcement is still lax in rural areas where tradition, poverty, and caste are prevalent. It is challenging for India to credibly lead international reform because of this disconnect between policy and reality.